PEER REVIEW HISTORY

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ARTICLE DETAILS

TITLE (PROVISIONAL)	How and why do women's groups (WGs) improve the quality of maternal and child health (MCH) care? A systematic review of the literature
AUTHORS	Canuto, Karla; Preston, Robyn; Rannard, Sam; Felton-Busch, Catrina; Geia, Lynore; Yeomans, Lee; Turner, Nalita; Thompson, Quitaysha; Carlisle, Karen; Evans, Rebecca; Passey, Megan; Larkins, Sarah; Redman-MacLaren, Michelle; Farmer, Jane; Muscat, Melody; Taylor, Judy

VERSION 1 – REVIEW

REVIEWER	Morrison, Joanna University College London, Institute for Global Health
REVIEW RETURNED	25-Aug-2021

GENERAL COMMENTS	This paper is an attempt to learn from the literature about how women's groups can improve maternal and newborn health, in order to transfer learning to their context. But unfortunately due to poorly defined review parameters and a lack of a theoretically informed analysis, authors have not learned anything which is of use to them. The discussion section re-states established rhetoric about better reporting and better integration of context but does not make reference to frameworks that would make this better, or discuss the barriers to presenting contextual information. Statements are very general and not specific enough to help authors who write about women's groups to improve their reporting. Given that authors didn't learn anything, the reader is also left without having learnt anything. It is a shame that this paper fell short of expectations and doesn't learn from other similar reviews (referenced below and some referenced in the paper) about how to draw out lessons from complex literature. Some specific points are below: 1. Defining the parameters of women's groups, participation, community, quality of care etc are really important to ensure the rigor of the search and screening process. There are several discrepancies in the article which make the screening and review process seem vague. For example that the groups should be 'participatory' is not in the inclusion criteria table, but yet in other sections (the discussion for example) it appears that articles were excluded on this basis. Another example is here: In this paper we used the term initiative as an alternative way to describe WGs as a self-determination process to identify, seek solutions and interrupt problematic issues consistent with empowerment of women in their decision making in seeking better

	MCH outcomes. This is fine, but not all WG follow this process – you state previously you are open to consider all types of groups, not just those that use this process. Another example is here: For this review, WGs are defined as community-based organised groups of women, that through a group process, identify needs and mobilise individual and/ or community action for health or wellbeing outcomes - The absence of 'maternal' from your definition for review is problematic. It appears that several relevant papers are missing – perhaps because they appear not to have considered context and process but have actually done so within the space limitations of an RCT publication. Can you provide more detail on 'hand searching' and how you located research groups etc to contact for grey literature. How was bias dealt with? The results section is not very engaging. It is unclear what is interesting in the results section, and how it relates to the questions of the review. The discussion section should centre around the research questions stated in the protocol: 1. What are the characteristics, contextual influences and mechanisms that are associated with the outcomes and effectiveness of PWGs? 2. What are the theoretical and conceptual approaches to PWGs? 3. What are the implications likely to inform Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander PWGs? One wonders why terminology has been changed from the protocol to this review paper – PWG to WG for example. It would be better to align the review with the protocol in this respect. Subheadings such as 'the how and why' are very vague, and authors are unable to draw any conclusions to answer their questions. Whilst authors state the need for a detailed analysis of how context affects functionality and outcomes, they appear to have only focused on broad descriptors in their results sections and not brought out some of the nuance has been written about in many of these papers. The fact that context is written about in an inconsistent way, doesn't mean to say it is not written about. Context is not something which can be easily 'boxed off' as a sub-heading. Careful consideration of context and how it interacts with interventions is well acknowledged in the literature, and instead of just re-stating this, authors could add usefully to the literature by analysing how this has been done in the papers they reviewed, and discuss useful ways to integrate or highlight contextual affects. Authors appear confused about why theory is important. P23 The role of theory is not just to inform data collection, it is mainly to improve implementation of interventions and understand if they are likely to work in different contexts. It would be helpful if there was some discussion about the different levels of theory – do authors refer to theories of change, or high-level theory only? How many papers had a robust theory of change?

	P24 Theory generation applicable to Australian Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander WGs is not possible from this systematic review, given the lack of contextually relevant data This is something which I would disagree with. There is literature from high income countries on women's groups (breast-feeding groups?), and many lessons have been learned across countries with different contexts. If authors thought that only Australian/High Income County papers were relevant, one wonders why they embarked on a global search? Authors would benefit from including reference to other systematic reviews, such as the one implemented by Lu Gram et al https://gh.bmj.com/content/4/6/e001972.abstract and discuss what their review adds to existing reviews – Marston et al is also referenced in the paper.

REVIEWER	Babu, Jobi Marian College Kuttikkanam, School of Social Work
REVIEW RETURNED	17-Sep-2021

GENERAL COMMENTS	The article is well written, followed the APA format, The methodology adopted open new pathways for the researches to think in a different dimension to approach qualitative research

REVIEWER	Reibel, Tracy Murdoch University, Ngangk Yira Research Centre for Aboriginal Health and Social Equity
REVIEW RETURNED	23-Sep-2021

GENERAL COMMENTS	This is an impressive, beautifully written, clear and revealing systematic review. There was little to find any fault with. All the interpretation was clearly articulated and the process of analysis was appropriate. I have noted some very minor edits which require attention, and one sentence that needs editing. These are highlighted in the attached manuscript. The mullet 'figure' is brilliant. This review is important and highly relevant to the range of work that is currently occurring across Australia, but will also be instructive to initiatives in other locations outside Australia. Many research groups will find this review highly useful. I agree that there is a requirement for publication of the role of women's groups in the development, implementation and 'measurement' of outcomes which incorporate some of the issues the authors have encountered in the literature selected for this review. These need to be framed in ways that are meaningful to community expectations as to what a successful outcome is when it comes to participatory or community based implementation of initiatives intended to improve MCH. However, the rigor of research being undertaken using Indigenous methods and Indigenous interpretative lenses also requires far greater acceptance from the research 'establishment'. The authorship group for this paper is to be commended. Thank you, it was a pleasure to review

VERSION 1 – AUTHOR RESPONSE

Comments	Response
Editor(s)' Comments to Author (if any): -Please revise the formatting of your abstract so that it follows the structured abstract outlined in the PRISMA guidelines: http://prisma-statement.org/Extensions/Abstracts . Specifically, please include search date limits and database names. -	**Thank you we have rewritten our abstract to follow these guidelines. However due to the word limitation of your submission system (300 words). The full abstract in the paper is different to the one on line.**
Please revise the Article Summary section of your manuscript (after the abstract). This section should only contain up to five short bullet points on the 'Strengths and limitations', no longer than one sentence each, that relate specifically to the methods. The aims or results of the study should not be summarised here.	**Thank you we have rewritten the article summary**
As part of your revision, please consider updating your search results to the present time	**We have considered updating the research results and we acknowledge the usefulness of searching to the present time. There is a very limited timeline in which to complete major revisions to this paper which makes it impossible for searching, screening, extracting, analysing and changing results should papers be included. These data have been updated until the end of January 2021.**
It is not necessary to include the protocol paper in your Supplementary Files, as long as it is cited in the manuscript	**Thank you, we have removed the protocol paper**
Formatting Amendments (where applicable): 1. Required figure/s format: - Figures can be supplied in TIFF, JPG or PDF format (figures in document, excel or powerpoint format will not be accepted), we also request that they have a resolution of at least 300 dpi and 90mm x 90mm of width. Please see the following link for further details on preparing images for submission: https://authors.bmj.com/writing-and-formatting/formatting-your-paper/	**Thank you we have reformatted Figures 1 and 2.**
2. Required Supplementary format: - Please re-upload your Supplementary files in PDF format.	**Thank you we have reloaded in the appropriate format.**
Reviewer: 1 **Dr. Joanna Morrison, University College London** Comments to the Author: This paper is an attempt to learn	**Thank you to reviewer 1 for making these comments about the review parameters and lack of theoretically informed analysis. This has enabled our team to think through to points raised and make corrections and/or changes in the**

from the literature about how women's groups can improve maternal and newborn health, in order to transfer learning to their context. But unfortunately due to poorly defined review parameters and a lack of a theoretically informed analysis, authors have not learned anything which is of use to them. The discussion section re-states established rhetoric about better reporting and better integration of context but does not make reference to frameworks that would make this better, or discuss the barriers to presenting contextual information. Statements are very general and not specific enough to help authors who write about women's groups to improve their reporting. Given that authors didn't learn anything, the reader is also left without having learnt anything. It is a shame that this paper fell short of expectations and doesn't learn from other similar reviews (referenced below and some referenced in the paper) about how to draw out lessons from complex literature.	**document. Specifically we have addressed (1) the review parameters, (2) the critique that the review analysis was not theoretically informed, and (3) that the review is not of value.** **1 We agree that there are several dissimilar statements defining WGs. This has been addressed and the definition of WGs is clarified as that which is in the inclusion criteria. Statements that could be read as definitions have been removed or a note made about the point of introducing them.** **2 The review was theoretically informed using an Australian conceptual typology to classify the community participation that occurred in each of the studies.(P.14) The conceptual typology was developed from empirical data about community participation in varied settings in Australia. We developed concepts of contributions, instrumental, empowerment and developmental participation and used these to analyse participation in the included documents in the review. We have strengthened the reference to these concepts in the results. (Page 18-19). Furthermore, we used the groups of participation type to compare against other factors (such as facilitation) to see if there was alignment between the predominant type of community participation. We have highlighted these findings in the results. (Page 19)** Our Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander colleagues provided concepts from an Indigenous lens about group functioning; the importance of culture and relationships, that respect is central, previously published by our group. This enabled an analysis of the studies reported in the paper from an Australian Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander perspective. We came to the conclusion that the concepts relevant to Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander group work were rarely found in the studies included in the review. We argue that the findings are of value to us and to other readers, as they demonstrate a clear lack of evidence regarding HOW women's groups function to achieve their outcomes. We have made changes to the paper to suggest a framework for reporting concepts about group process intra-group relationships, facilitation styles, and decision-making. We have proposed a way to analyse contextual factors at the micro, meso, and macro level in relation to their effect on group functioning.(P 21) We conducted the review in a genuine attempt to ensure we used all relevant information in conducting the WoMB project.
1. Defining the parameters of women's groups, participation,	Defining the parameters of women's groups is of the utmost importance. We agree that there is lack of clarity in the paper,

community, quality of care etc are really important to ensure the rigor of the search and screening process. There are several discrepancies in the article which make the screening and review process seem vague. For example that the groups should be 'participatory' is not in the inclusion criteria table, but yet in other sections (the discussion for example) it appears that articles were excluded on this basis.	but not in the review. The definition used in the systematic review is at P. 9. The other statements that could be read as definitions have been removed. There remains a discussion about Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander women's preference to use the term initiative rather than intervention. The description of WGs in Aboriginal and Islander health has been removed Use of the term participatory: Rarely, in the international literature are WG's termed participatory women's groups. Hence the criterion for inclusion was not the use of the term 'participatory' because this would have excluded a lot of papers. We used a criterion of the program/intervention involving any aspect of community WGs planning, acting, learning, and reviewing MCH improvements. No papers were excluded for not mentioning participatory. They were excluded only if they did not include any aspect of community women's groups involvement in planning, acting, learning, and reviewing MCH improvements. In addition, the criteria PICO headings Process states that the paper includes some description of the process of WGs or a ny factors influencingthe process.
Another example is here: In this paper we used the term initiative as an alternative way to describe WGs as a self-determination process to identify, seek solutions and interrupt problematic issues consistent with empowerment of women in their decision making in seeking better MCH outcomes. This is fine, but not all WG follow this process – you state previously you are open to consider all types of groups, not just those that use this process.	**We have removed this statement even though it was in the paper to share Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander perspectives of WGs. We agree it could have been confusing.**
Another example is here: For this review, WGs are defined as community-based organised groups of women, that through a group process, identify needs and mobilise individual and/ or community action for health or wellbeing outcomes - The absence of 'maternal' from your definition for review is problematic.	**There is only one definition of a WG used for the review and that is in the inclusion criteria.** Maternal was included in our search terms as a synonym in the infant terms group (so results had to have mothers (or a synonym) AND maternal (or another word around baby)
It appears that several relevant papers are missing – perhaps because they appear not to have considered context and process but have actually done so within the space limitations of an RCT	If the papers did not make any mention of process, then they may have been excluded in the first screening stage if not mentioned in title/abstract.

publication.	
Can you provide more detail on 'hand searching' and how you located research groups etc to contact for grey literature. How was bias dealt with?	**Thank you for the opportunity to provide more detail on hand searching. The following has been included in the paper at P. 10** *The selection of groups to be included in grey literature searching was based on the researcher's professional experience in the field and knowledge of key organisations within this space.' Two reviewers (RP, JT) contacted authors; research groups in Australia and internationally and WGs by email to obtain grey literature that covered processes or mode of working of community-based WGs. Hand-searching, the reviewing of hard copy papers from journals or departments that were not available on data bases at the time, was conducted. No new content was included in the final review from these inquiries.* *Potential bias was considered but it was not possible to exclude it in hand searching - some potentially useful organisations may not have been included.*
The results section is not very engaging. It is unclear what is interesting in the results section, and how it relates to the questions of the review.	**We agree with this comment. The entire results section from P 16-19 has been reworked with data placed under the review question headings and interesting aspects have been highlighted e.g., the relationship between community participation types and group processes P. 19**
The discussion section should centre around the research questions stated in the protocol: 1. What are the characteristics, contextual influences and mechanisms that are associated with the outcomes and effectiveness of PWGs? 2. What are the theoretical and conceptual approaches to PWGs? 3. What are the implications likely to inform Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander PWGs? One wonders why terminology has been changed from the protocol to this review paper – PWG to WG for example. It would be better to align the review with the protocol in this respect.	**Thank you for this comment. The discussion centres now around the research questions and suggests some approaches that might help in analysing group structures and processes and integrating the influence of contextual factors. Some examples of nuanced discussion of contextual factors, from the studies, are presented. (P.**17) Yes, the point about terminology change is important. We made the change because the protocol was written prior to the data-base searching being conducted. We made an assumption that the term PWG was commonplace in the literature. We found it was not.
Subheadings such as 'the how and why' are very vague, and authors are unable to draw any conclusions to answer their questions. Whilst authors state the need for a detailed analysis of how context affects functionality and outcomes, they appear to have only focused on broad descriptors in their results sections and not brought out some	**We agree with this point and have included in the results two examples of nuanced discussions of context and how this was integrated. We propose that contextual factors affecting groups be analysed at the macro, meso, and micro level which might make it easier to report on them. (P21)**

of the nuance has been written about in many of these papers. The fact that context is written about in an inconsistent way, doesn't mean to say it is not written about. Context is not something which can be easily 'boxed off' as a sub-heading. Careful consideration of context and how it interacts with interventions is well acknowledged in the literature, and instead of just re-stating this, authors could add usefully to the literature by analysing how this has been done in the papers they reviewed, and discuss useful ways to integrate or highlight contextual affects.	
Authors appear confused about why theory is important. P23 The role of theory is not just to inform data collection, it is mainly to improve implementation of interventions and understand if they are likely to work in different contexts. It would be helpful if there was some discussion about the different levels of theory – do authors refer to theories of change, or high-level theory only? How many papers had a robust theory of change?	**We thank the reviewer for noting this omission about theory on P 22. The sentence now reads:** ***"The value in theory-driven initiatives, is that theory might provide a foundation for consistent evidence gathering about process and outcomes which in turn might inform more effective initiatives"*** **Again, thank the reviewer for acknowledging that there is a discussion to be had about the different levels of theory used and whether or not papers had a robust theory of change. We could not do this in this review as many of the papers were without a clear description of how, and at what level of the initiative, they used theory. Making an assessment about the use of a robust theory of change would have been most difficult.**
P24 Theory generation applicable to Australian Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander WGs is not possible from this systematic review, given the lack of contextually relevant data This is something which I would disagree with. There is literature from high income countries on women's groups (breast-feeding groups?), and many lessons have been learned across countries with different contexts. If authors thought that only Australian/High Income County papers were relevant, one wonders why they embarked on a global search? Authors would benefit from including reference to other systematic reviews, such as the one implemented by Lu Gram et al https://gh.bmj.com/content/4/6/e0	**We consider it is most important that concepts reflecting Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander world views, values, meanings become available nationally and internationally. Our comment about theory generation applicable to Australian Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander women's groups is that the concepts central to an Australian Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander viewpoint about WGs the centrality of culture and relationships, and respect were not generally used in the documents. Or they were not used in the same way in the studies reviewed (apart from Lowell, et al). We didn't know this at the outset of the systematic review. While we agree that lessons have been learned across countries with different contexts, adding to available concepts might help.** Our systematic review adds to existing systematic reviews about the functioning of WGs in MCH improvement in that it covers WGs in both high- and low-income settings, identifies the theory underpinning the WGs, and classifies the conceptual approach to participation. It also introduces an Australian Indigenous perspective into analysis of WGs used to improve

01972.abstract and discuss what their review adds to existing reviews – Marston et al is also referenced in the paper.	MCH. This is introduced to the paper at P. 25
Reviewer: 2 **Prof. Jobi Babu, Marian College Kuttikkanam** Comments to the Author: The article is well written, followed the APA format, The methodology adopted open new pathways for the researches to think in a different dimension to approach qualitative research	**Thank you for your review.**
Reviewer: 3 **Dr. Tracy Reibel, Murdoch University** Comments to the Author: This is an impressive, beautifully written, clear and revealing systematic review. There was little to find any fault with. All the interpretation was clearly articulated and the process of analysis was appropriate. I have noted some very minor edits which require attention, and one sentence that needs editing. These are highlighted in the attached manuscript. The mullet 'figure' is brilliant. This review is important and highly relevant to the range of work that is currently occurring across Australia, but will also be instructive to initiatives in other locations outside Australia. Many research groups will find this review highly useful. I agree that there is a requirement for publication of the role of women's groups in the development, implementation and 'measurement' of outcomes which incorporate some of the issues the authors have encountered in the literature selected for this review. These need to be framed in ways that are meaningful to community expectations as to what a successful outcome is when it comes to participatory or community based implementation of initiatives intended to improve MCH. However, the rigor of research being undertaken using Indigenous methods and Indigenous interpretative lenses also requires far greater	**Thank you for your review we have addressed the minor edits as outlined in the file. It was helpful that this reviewer supported the incorporation of an Indigenous interpretive lens.**

acceptance from the research 'establishment'. The authorship group for this paper is to be commended. Thank you, it was a pleasure to review	

VERSION 2 – REVIEW

REVIEWER	Reibel, Tracy Murdoch University, Ngangk Yira Research Centre for Aboriginal Health and Social Equity
REVIEW RETURNED	11-Jan-2022

GENERAL COMMENTS	Overall, the paper is still of high quality and addresses the detailed Reviewer 1 comments. I have noted some minor amendments to the paper following the revision submitted, which if attended to may clarify the results and discussion. these are highlighted and with comments in the attached

VERSION 2 – AUTHOR RESPONSE

Responses to Reviewer 3		
No.	**Comments**	Response
1.	Overall, the paper is still of high quality and addresses the detailed Reviewer 1 comments. I have noted some minor amendments to the paper following the revision submitted, which if attended to may clarify the results and discussion. these are highlighted and with comments in the attached	**Thank you for your comments,**
2.	**p. 4** there seems to be a word missing here	**Thank you we have rewritten this sentence.**
3.	**p. 6** This sentence would be a new paragraph if you accept the suggestion	**Thank you we have made a new paragraph**
4	**p. 7** this paragraph defining women's groups more appropriately should follow the third sentence of the opening paragraph. The explanation of the word intervention can then follow with the definition of women's groups clearly articulated for the purpose of the SR	**Thank you we have changed around the paragraphs**
5.	**p. 7** involving rather than with	**Thank you we have made this change**
6	**p. 10** if the collective of researchers (as it likely is), move the apostrophe to the end of the word	**Thank you we have made this change.**
7	**p. 14** The meaning of this sentence is not clear. Do you mean that the team members considered concepts for WGs relevant to Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander context which includes	**Yes, this was our meaning we have changed the sentence, thank you for the suggestion.**

	the primacy of culture, relationships and respect?	
8	Consistent use of capitals is required throughout - these seem to alternate between no capitals (as in sentence before) and capitals (as highlighted).	**We have changed to lower case throughout to be consistent with the World Bank terminology.**
9.	**p. 15** insert some - 'some groups also included some men'	**Thank you, we have included this phrase.**
10	**p. 16** I'm not sure the association is articulated. Either this sentence needs to be deleted or requires qualification as to what the association is. Describing the different types of group structure and style of leadership and facilitation is appropriate but I don't see that the first sentence adds anything	**Thank you we have deleted this sentence**
11	**p.17** formatting	**Changed italics**
12	**p.17** formatting	**Changed italics**
13	**p.19** do you mean 'From an Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander perspective that within-group relationships would be considered fundamental, and likely influence all aspects of WGs developed for MCH purposes'?	**Thank you have we have changed the sentence**
14	**p.19** delete rather, insert 'and is consistent with...'	**Thank you we have changed the sentence.**
15	**p.19** this sentence needs a qualifier. Perhaps 'More of this type of analysis would be useful in establishing the key factors relevant to successful WGs' or something along those lines This would also fit well with what you say in the following paragraphs	**Thank you we have changed the sentence.**
16	**p.19 – 20** something is missing here - the meaning of the sentence needs reviewing	**Thank you we have emphasised participatory as an adjective, as in components of the health system should be participatory. There is a further sentence to clarify the process of implementation.**
17	**p.21** see previous comment regarding consistency of capitalisation of word	**As above we have changed**
18	**p. 21** an rather than the	**Changed**
19	**p. 21** delete highlighted words - these don't add anything and as the 'travelling model' is not explained it doesn't need to be in this sentence. The meaning is clear and and important notation regarding transposing programs	**Thank you we have deleted these words.**
20	**p. 21** should this be PWG or WG?	**Thank you we have changed to WG**
21	**p.22** Perhaps 'might inform the effectiveness of future initiatives'	**Thank you we have added this phrase.**
22	**p.25** should this be 'links'?	**Yes, thank you we have changed.**

VERSION 3 – REVIEW

REVIEWER	Reibel, Tracy Murdoch University, Ngangk Yira Research Centre for Aboriginal Health and Social Equity
REVIEW RETURNED	27-Jan-2022

GENERAL COMMENTS	Well done to the authors - this is a well constructed and important paper as we move to developing more culturally safe models of care for Aboriginal women. Women's Groups offer an opportunity for peer learning and the exchange of well founded and wise counsel. Thank you for the opportunity to review this paper